Vito Volterra



Born in 1860 in Ancona, Italy, the son of a Jewish cloth merchant, Vito Volterra grew up in poverty. Despite this, in 1883, aged just 23, he secured a position as professor of mechanics at the University of Pisa and began a career as a mathematician. Further professorships at the universities of Turin and Rome followed. In 1900, Volterra married, fathering six children, although only four survived to adulthood. He was made a senator of the Kingdom of Italy in 1905 and worked on the development of military airships during World War I. In 1931, Volterra refused to swear loyalty to Italy's fascist dictator Benito Mussolini and was dismissed from the University of Rome. Forced to work abroad, he only returned to Italy for a short time before his death in 1940.